# 2-1 Culture Is learned

Culture is a system of shared beliefs, values, customs behaviours, artifacts.

Through learning, culture can be shared, reinforced and inherited by people in the particular cultural group

Then a question pops up How do people learn culture

1. Firstly, we learn culture through language.

Let's have a look at the following Chinese proverbs

e.g ① 三人行必有我师焉

When I walk with two others, there must be one whom I can learn from.

② 水能载舟亦能覆舟

The water that bears the boat is the same that swallows it up.

③ 前车之鉴

One man's fault is other's lesson.

④ 玉不琢不成器

The finest diamond must be cut.

⑤ 树大招风

Tall trees catch much wind.

# Life and Culture

On the one hand, the group members can assimilate the wisdom into their own individuals' belief system.

On the other hand, by learning and using proverbs, people can learn the culture of that group.

In short, culture can be learned through proverbs.

2. More than that, people love stories.
in various forms: folk tales, legends, myths, epics, ballads, etc.

① For example, the 4-year-old Kongrong's generosity in picking the smallest pear, leaving bigger ones to other kids.

② the 90-year-old Yu Gong's determination in moving a mountain on his own.

③ the founder of the Chinese Shu-Han Dynasty, Liu Bei's sincerity in his three visits to Zhu Geliang's cottage to invite them as the military advisor.

So, people can learn culture through stories.

3. Beyond stories, art is also a good channel for us to know a culture. Art is a symbolic way of communicating.

One of most important functions of art is to communicate, display and reinforce important cultural themes and values.

For example, the traditional Chinese ink painting aims to express the spiritual world. While the oil painting in Western countries quests for truth and advocates realism.

The traditional Chinese architecture makes use of wood for symmetrical and and colorful buildings while western countries prefer stones painted in white, grey or beige

4. Today, people are bombed with information by all kinds of means. books, radio, magazines, newspapers, television, cinema Internet, etc.

# 2-4 Culture is Adaptive

Population growth, Environmental transition, Political reform

Technological invention, cultural contact.

1.
This ability is defined as cultural adaptation. A most impressive case to show that culture is adaptive is the development of agriculture.

2. related to transportation

To survive in an increasingly polluted modern world. people are gradually aware of the urgency of environmental protection and try their best to make a difference in their behaviours and habits when travelling around. In urban areas. electric vehicles are being developed charging points are setting up incentives for green transportation. are being offered by governments.

3. language learning also manifests how adaptive culture is. The modern technology has transformed language learning in numerous ways making it more accessible, engaging and effective Language learning resources are now available to a wider audience including people in remote and

4. Mobile apps. online courses, and language exchange platforms have made it possible to learn a language anytime., anywhere. and at a pace that suits the learner

Nowadays. language learning is more motivating. engaging and interactive. facilitated by gamification, speech recognition and chatbots, etc.

For example

① Movie industry

While traditional movie theaters were once the go-to destination for film fans many people now prefer to watch movies from the comfort of their own homes.

Streaming service offers a wider variety of

② Mobile apps.

Mobile apps, online courses, and language exchange platforms have made it possible to learn a language anytime, anywhere, and at a pace that suits the learner

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# 3.1 Cultural patterns

Cultural patterns can be defined as shared beliefs, values, norms and social practices that are stable overtime

⇒ which lead to roughly similar behaviours

## Three cultural theories

① Context-culture Theory ② Value Orientation Theory

③ Theory on Dimensions of cultural Variability

Context-culture Theory is a term presented by American anthropologist Edward T. Hall in his book Beyond Culture

It's based on the tendency of people to deal with messages in routine communication The messages can be conveyed and received through language while they can also be also be sent and taken through the environment or the settings of communication which is called context.

In a high context culture as people assume they share similar experiences and expectations from which inferences are drawn many things are left unsaid.

The words uttered usually communicate a complex message beyond the surface meaning very effectively to an in-group but less effectively outside that group

These words are typically implicit layered and nuanced

On the contrary, in a lower context culture the communicators need to be much more direct and explicit because it's assumed that people have a lower level of shared context.

It means that the people dont have the same reference points or the same body of knowledge or relationships

So in a low context society people tend to believe that effective communication is blunt and clear and they focus on making sure that the messages are passed and articulated without vagueness or ambiguity

Members from a high context culture are heavily dependent on the context of their communication rather than words.

The following two cases

The first case is shared by Erin Meyer the author of The Culture Map

Once she had a Turkish client in Istanbul who was telling her all of the issues he had with his new American boss. Erin asked, If your boss were here, would you tell him what you are telling me. He said, well, you know, Erin, I didn't hide it. so he could see it if he wanted to see it. Erin saw the problem immediately and told him that his American boss probably didn't see it because the Turkish man's intention was clear only to his high context culture members. He failed to get his intention across with clear-cut and accurate words to his boss from a lower context culture

Another failure happened between an American teacher and his bright chinese assistant

Once they went on a business trip for a feasibility study the assistant asked her teacher after a long walk, sir, are you tired? Do you feet hurt? Do you want to have a rest? Do you want a drink. And the American teacher took these questions in the American way and answered directly. Oh, No. I'm ok. I can keep going

considerable adj. 大量的.

Ambiguous adj. 不清楚的;模棱两可的

Garden of Eden 伊甸园

Noah's ark

# 3.2.1 Kluckhohn-Strodtbeck's Values Orientation Theory

Value orientations are cross-cultural theory of human values.

According to Kluckhohn and Strodtbeck value Orientations are choices and preferences of a cultural group when they are dealing with some universal problems rising with basic existential needs

Generally, the value orientations held by people can fall into five dimensions or reflect five areas of concerns

which are: human nature, relationship with nature_relationship with time human activities and relationship with people or social relations

It has been accepted that uncovering these values and devising means of measuring them would provide valuable insights into the similarities and differences between people from differing cultural backgrounds

The five cultural dimensions will be introduced in two separate videos

Now, let's embark on today's journey to explore three of them with the following questions

Q1: what is the inherent nature of human beings

The answer varies 1. Human Nature is good. This view posits that humans are inherently good and that any evil or immoral behaviour is caused by external factors.

e.g Chinese Taoism and Confucianism holds that people are born good.

2. Human Nature is Evil

This view holds that humans are inherently selfish and violent and that moral behaviour is only a thin veneer over a dark and violent nature.

Thus, cultures with this orientation insist that the society must exercise strong measures to keep the evil impulses of people in check and

rely heavily on the enforcement of laws and regulations

3. Human Nature is Neutral or Ambiguous

This view argues that human nature is neither purely good nor entirely evil but rather a complex mixture of both.

People have the potential to do great good. and the capacity of doing considerable harm.

Q2: What is the relationship between human beings and nature?

Some societies believe nature is a powerful force human beings should fear and worship. This submissiveness in the face of natural and /or supernatural forces is labeled as "subjugation to nature"

Other societies are more likely to embrace a "mastery over nature" attitude. Where groups respond to problems of nature by exercising mastery people attempt to exert control over nature. The attempt to conquer space resulting in the moon landings achieved by US astronauts has often been cited as an example of the assertive attitude to nature displayed in American culture.

Between the two relationships mentioned above are the societies who believe humans are wise to strive to live in "harmony with nature". Cultures that are positive in practicing holistic form of medicine advocating sustainable agriculture developing renewable energy building eco-friendly houses and conserving wildlife and natural habitats most probably cherish the orientation of living "in harmony with nature".

Q3. What are the three time orientations?

1. Past orientation: This type of orientation focus on the events and experiences of the past

=> learn from history; preserve the traditions

2. Present Orientation: This orientation focuses on the present moment and what is happening right now.

3. Future Orientation: This orientation focuses on what will happen in the future.

# 3.2.2 Kluckhohn-Strodtbeck's Values Orientation Theory

## 4. human activities and relationship with people

### Q4: What are the main modes of human activities?

There are people who "value being" or who emphasize on inherent worth and personal identity which are independent of external factors such as accomplishments or material possessions It's about who we are at our core. It encompasses our beliefs about what is most important and meaningful in life. Such as love, happiness, compassion and personal growth. This tendency of "valuing being" is often found in traditional Eastern cultures such as China, Japan and India. In these cultures, a greater emphasis is placed on living in the present moment and finding inner peace rather than always striving for achievement or success. Mindfulness and being at peace with oneself is highly valued. People who "value doing" on the other hand are those who prefer actions and who seek for success. In societies that are primarily oriented to "doing" people are likely to think of the inactive life as a wasted life believing that human worth is measured by the sum of accomplishments The united states and many European countries tend to place a greater value on doing or achieving things. That's why these cultures applaud for hard work, success and productivity. People are often judged by what they do and what they achieve rather than who they are. People who "value becoming" have faith in that there is always room for growth and that one can always strive to become a better version of oneself regardless of age or state in life. In Eastern philosophy, particularly in the teachings of Taoism and Buddhism the pursuit of self-enlightenment and the cultivation of wisdom both in this lifetime and in future reincarnation are highly valued Another example is the popularity of motivational speakers, life coaches and self-help books about self-improvement and personal development in some Western societies. Their focus is on setting and achieving personal goals developing new skills and knowledge and striving for growth and fulfillment in all aspects of life

Q5: How should individuals relate to each other or how a society is organized?

To understand how relationships are formed in a culture can help us answer this question from individual lineal or collateral perspectives

individual, lineal, collateral

Americans stress autonomy and differentiation holding that the individual is the primary unit of society people with this orientation are likely to believe that each person should have control over his/her own destiny. The emphasis is on individuals who make decisions, take responsibilities, enjoy rights, and fulfill promises, independently of others. People in other societies consider it most natural that a society should be organized lineally, or hierarchically. In a culture valuing lineality people hold to the view that some people are born to lead and others to follow. For example, cultures of aristocratic origin like England defer to higher authorities within a group such as fathers and leaders to make important decisions Also included are cultures such as China, Japan and Thailand. For example, the concept of "keigo" is ingrained in Japanese culture to show respect for authority or senior people with formal language, polite phrases and deferential behaviors in social and business interactions. The idea of lineal relationships is valued because it helps to maintain social order stability, and harmony within the community. Other societies including France stress role obligations and in-group interdependence kinship bonds and extended family bonds. This is collaterality orientation focuses on an individuals group membership rather than the individual himself. But different from people in lineal relationship individuals in this culture have their own important role to play.

# 3.3 Cultural Dimensions Theory a framework proposed by Dutch psychologist Greet Hofstede

Hofstede categorizes cultural differences into six basic dimensions of cultural values which will be introduced in detail

## 1. Power distance

Power distance refers to how openly a society or culture accepts differences between people such as hierachies in workplace

In other words. it means how a society views and deals with the inequality among its members

In high power distance countries such as Japan, Mexico and Philippines people openly understand and accept the existence of privileged class and the less powerful group accept their position in this hierarchical society showing respect and obedience to the people with a higher status.

In this countries, the senior person is like a farther figure and the infevior one automatically respects and obeys the orders without speaking their own minds out

While in countries of lower power distance such as Australia, Denmark, Norway and Sweden, people tend to struggle for the equal distribution of power and superiors and subordinates are more likely to see each other as equals

## 2. Individualism vs Collectivism

This dimension is the degree to which social members are integrated into group as well as their perceived obligations to and dependence on group

Simply put. it's how important the individual interest or the collective interest is in the eyes of the social members

The individualistic culture emphasizes individual achievement and autonomy while the collective one stresses group loyalty and interdependence

In an individualistic country like the USA people have the tendency to take care of themselves and their immediate circle of family and friends perhaps at the expense of the rest of the society

In a collective country like China, Singapore and Japan, people are expected to prioritize the goals and interest of the wider community, showing a higher tendency of self-sacrifice

## 3. Uncertainty avoidance

It refers to a society's tolerance of ambiguity

With high uncertainty avoidance a culture concerns more with minimizing uncertainty and avoiding ambiguity while a culture with low uncertainty avoidance is more comfortable with ambiguity and uncertainty. In a former culture, traditional beliefs and behaviour patterns are rigidly held and there is a strong need for rules. orders and regulations

Examples are Japan and German where people may show a perfevence for stability and low risk decisions

On the contrary in the latter culture there is a more relaxed and tolerant attitude toward change, uncertainty and ambiguity Denmark, Costa Rica and Australia are typical examples where people are more likely to handle unknown and unexpected situations.

Companies may appear less formal and structured requiring less rules Schools may encourage to "think outside the box", etc.

## 4. Masculinity Vs Femininity

Masculine-oriented cultures emphasize the distinct social gender roles.

competitiveness, and material success. while feminine-oriented cultures highlight concern for people, quality of life and relationships

In a masculine culture like Germany success is measured by career achievements while in a feminine culture like Norway, Switzerland and New zealand success is measured by happiness and well-being

## 5. long-term orientation VS short-term orientation

This dimension examines the social members' acceptance of delay of gratification in terms of material, emotional and social needs.

long-term orientation fouses on future development and values, persistence perseverance, growth and thrift wille short-term orientation fourses on present and a near future expecting immediate gratification and reward

Societies with long-term orientation such as China and korea, value history, traditions and social obligations, hold reservations for dramatic social changes and tend to plan for the future

However. in a short-term-oriented culture like the Us or the Uk people are more practical fous more on instant gratification and quick solutions

Then, we can try to explain why Asian families generally have a higher saving rate than American family, can't we?

## 6. Self-indulgence VS Restraint

This dimension demonstrates how people try to control their desires and impulses.

In indulgent cultures like the Us, Canada and Spain, freedom of speech and behaviours are pursued and people tend to place higher importance on leisure and pleasure.

In other words, people enjoy life to the fullest less concerned with guilt and shame

Conversely, in restrained cultures like Japan and Saudi Arabia, people are expected to suppress their desires and adhere to strict codes of conduct

Now that we have had some idea about the six major dimensions of cultural values we can try to figure out the reason for us to learn the cultural Dimensions Theory in cross-cultural Communication